

PLSC 197 / SODA 110N: Social Data, Technology, and Artificial Intelligence

Assignment 5: Ranking Redesign

Assignment

The topic this week is recommendation systems.

1. *Choose a platform* with which you are familiar, and that regularly makes recommendations. Suggestions include:
 - TikTok’s *For You* feed
 - Spotify’s *Discover Weekly*
 - Netflix’s homepage ranking
 - YouTube’s autoplay queue
 - Instagram’s *Explore* page
 - Shein’s *For You* feed
 - LinkedIn’s job recommendations
 - Amazon’s product rankings
2. *Diagnose the current system*: Briefly describe what value the platform currently optimizes for and what metric it uses to do so. Be specific – “engagement” is not enough. What kind of engagement? Measured how? Draw on the readings where relevant.
3. *State your redesign goal*: Name the value you want to prioritize and explain why it matters. Possibilities include – but are not limited to – diversity (of viewpoint, genre, creator background, etc.), user well-being, public interest or civic relevance, economic equality, accuracy, and serendipity / welcome surprise.
4. Redesign your platform’s recommendation system to optimize for a different value or set of values (e.g., diversity, public interest, well-being). Include discussions of the following:
 - (a) What data would you need? Include information on and/or signals and input from users, characteristics of content, and other possible data.
 - (b) What tradeoffs would arise? *For example*, think about the balance between user privacy vs. data requirements, personalization vs. diversity (broadening the platform’s appeal), and/or engagement vs. content quality. How would the change affect those aspects of the platform? What would improve, and what would get worse?

Details

Your assignment should include a separate title page with your name, the name of the course, the name of the assignment, and the date on which it was completed / submitted. The body of the written assignment should be *double-spaced*, in a conventionally-sized (11 or 12 point) font. Each written part of the assignment should be as short or long as you deem necessary; a rough target might be a total of 3-4 pages. You need not cite any sources for this assignment, or include references, unless you choose to.

This assignment must be completed and submitted by Wednesday, October 21, 2026 at 11:59 p.m. ET. Submit your assignment by *creating / converting your assignment into PDF format*, and emailing it to Dr. Zorn (at zorn@psu.edu). Assignments received after the due date will not be accepted. This assignment is worth a possible 100 points.